air forum | WASHINGTON, D.C.
May 26-29, 2026
Pre-Conference: May 25-26, 2026

celebrating 60 years air

Making Higher Ed Data Speak – Storytelling Frameworks That Drive Impact

The Challenges We Face



The Challenges We Face





You have
tons of data



Your audience has
limited time

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Attention is
fragmented

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Stakeholders have
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Audiences forget **statistics quickly**

The Opportunities



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Opportunity:

Simplify
Complex Data

The Opportunities



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Opportunity:

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Opportunity:

Communicate
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Opportunity:

Capture
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The Opportunities



You have tons of data

Opportunity:

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Your audience has limited time

Opportunity:

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Attention is fragmented

Opportunity:

Capture Attention



Stakeholders have different priorities

Opportunity:

Personalize Insights



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You have **tons of data**

Opportunity:

Simplify Complex Data



Your audience has **limited time**

Opportunity:

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Attention is **fragmented**

Opportunity:

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Stakeholders have **different priorities**

Opportunity:

Personalize Insights



Audiences forget **statistics quickly**

Opportunity:

Improve Retention

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Making Higher Ed Data Speak – Storytelling Frameworks That Drive Impact

Presenters

MISSOURI S&T



Wayne Jones, EdD

A.V.C. for Institutional Effectiveness & Chief Institutional Research Officer



Brianna Reddick

Associate Director of Analytics



Lakshmi Ponnurasan

Data Analyst II

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Why Storytelling Wins?



Why Storytelling Wins?

DATA + STORY = IMPACT



Builds Connection

Stories create emotional connections that inspire and resonate.



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Stories communicate who we are, what we value, and where we're going.



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Drives Impact

Stories highlight outcomes and demonstrate the real-world impact of education.

Inspires Action

Great stories motivate audiences to support, enroll, and advocate.

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1. The Comparison Framework

1. THE COMPARISON FRAMEWORK

A powerful thinking tool that helps us understand ideas deeply by looking at **similarities, differences,** and **reasons.**



CONCEPT

What?

Identify the topics or ideas to explore.

Why?

Understand the purpose behind comparing.

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What?

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Why?

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COMPARE

Look at what is similar.

CONTRAST

Examine what is different.

EXPLAIN

Provide reasons, insights, and implications.

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CORE LOGIC

01 COMPARE

Establish a baseline

Identify the key features, qualities, or aspects that are the **same.**

EXAMPLE Both countries have four seasons.

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03 EXPLAIN
Provide reasons/implications

Explain why the differences or similarities **matter.** Draw conclusions and consider the impact.

EXAMPLE: This affects agriculutre, lifestyle, and economy.

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Deeper understanding, better decisions, stronger insights.

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> Compare to **understand.**
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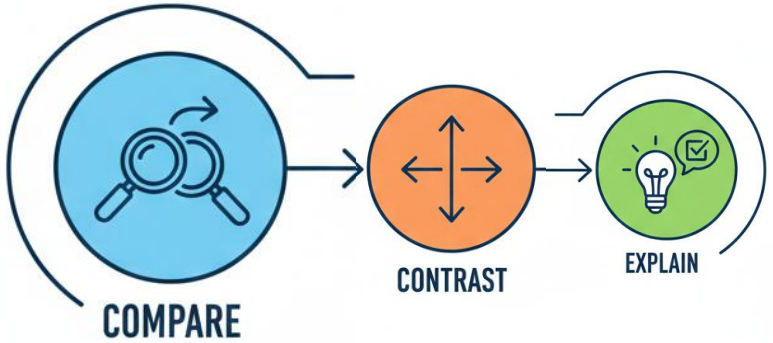
WHEN TO USE:

- When exploring new topics
- When analyzing texts or data
- When solving problems or making decisions
- When forming opinions

THINK CRITICALLY. COMPARE WISELY. EXPLAIN CLEARLY.

Compare:

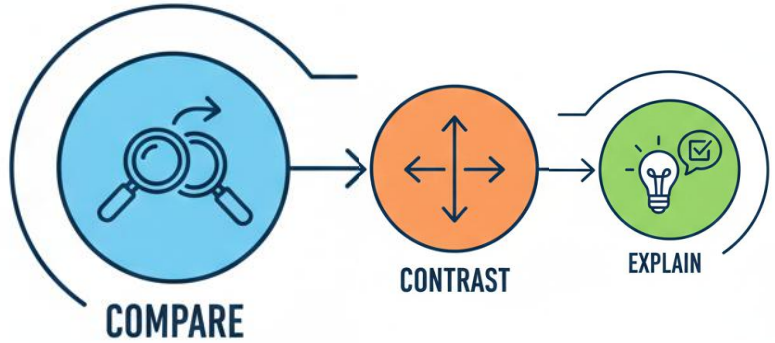
"What are we measuring this against?"



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Compare:

"What are we measuring this against?"



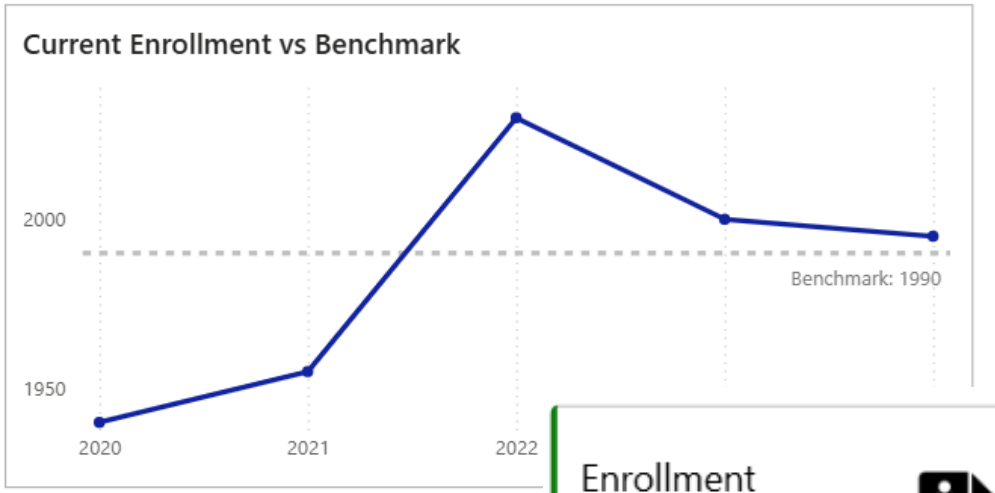
Common Higher Ed Comparisons

01 This year vs last year

02 This term vs previous term

03 Program A vs Program B

04 Institution vs benchmark



Enrollment

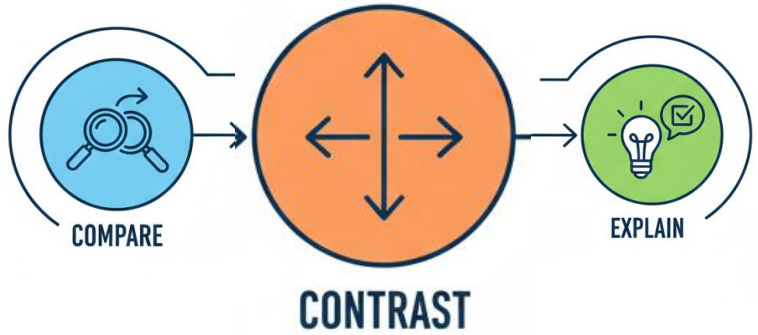
1955

PY Enrollment: 1940 ▲

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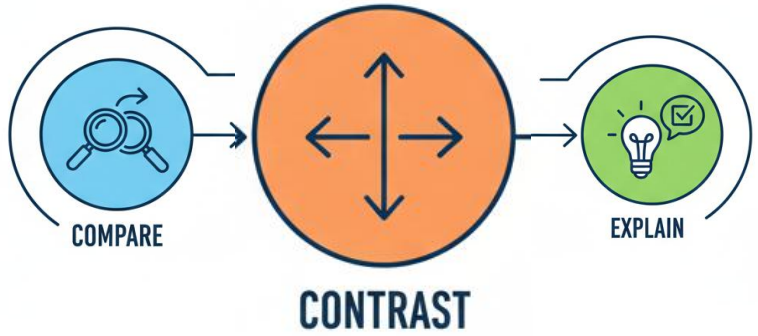
Contrast:

"Where is it different?"



Contrast:

"Where is it different?"



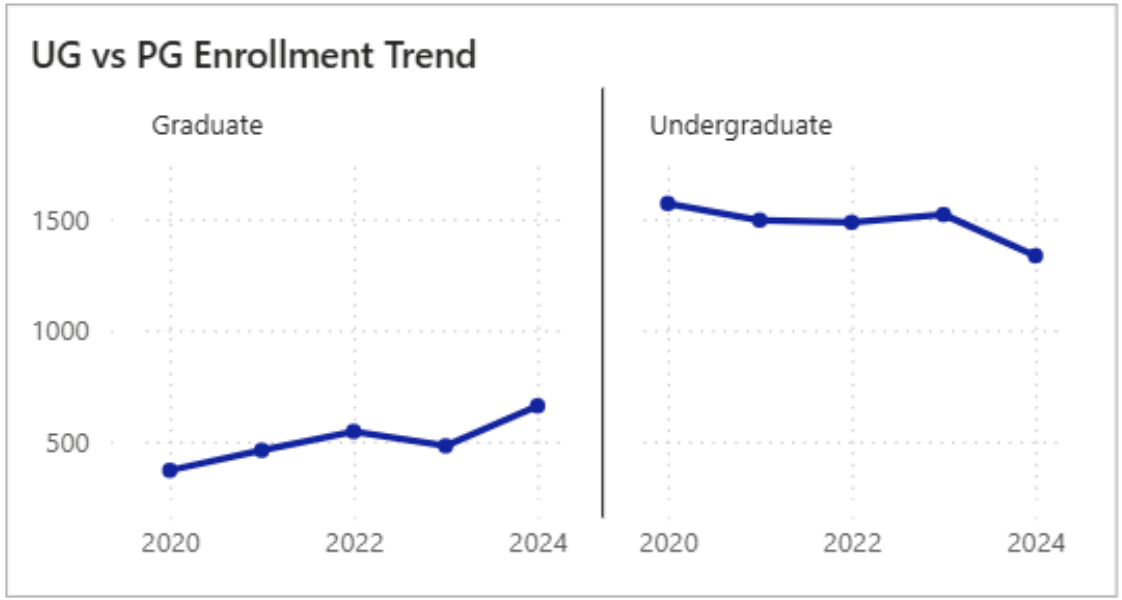
Common Higher Ed Comparisons

01 By college or department

02 By program level (UG vs Grad)

03 By demographic group

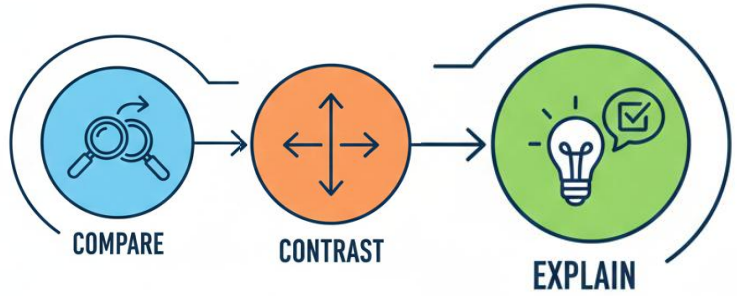
04 Domestic vs International



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Explain:

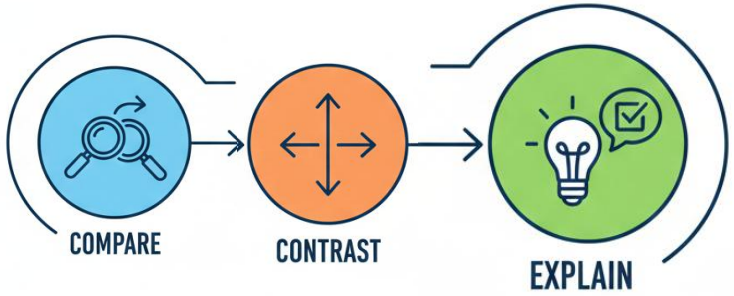
"Why is this happening?"



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Explain:

"Why is this happening?"



Explanation Comes From:

- Additional context
- Known events
- Correlated drivers
- Institutional knowledge



Data tells you what happened.

Explanation tells you why it happened.

Layering context and understanding drivers helps turn insights into better decisions.

Good explanations turn data into **understanding** and insights into **action**.

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Example

💡 **Power BI Storytelling Tip:**
Your dashboard should feel like it’s **answering questions in the same order** the viewer is thinking them.

UNIVERSITY OF FABRICLAND

Pipeline

2024 | 2025 | 2026

FTC | TRE

Fall | Spring

Apps
254

Prior Cycle **290** ▼ -36 (-12.4%)

Admits
90

Prior Cycle **81** ▲ 9 (11.1%)

Net Deposits
43

Prior Cycle **69** ▼ -26 (-37.7%)

Enrolled
38

Prior Cycle **55** ▼ -17 (-30.9%)

Pipeline

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- College
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Prior Cycle **290** ▼ -36 (-12.4%)

High School Visit	34	39
Direct Apply	36	38
College Fair	32	35
International Agent	32	33
Online Inquiry	30	
Referral	30	
Transfer Portal	27	
Common App	22	

Admits
90

Prior Cycle **81** ▲ 9 (11.1%)

International Agent	6	16
Online Inquiry	13	13
College Fair	4	12
Transfer Portal	12	
High School Visit	11	
Common App	5	10
Referral	10	
Direct Apply	6	13

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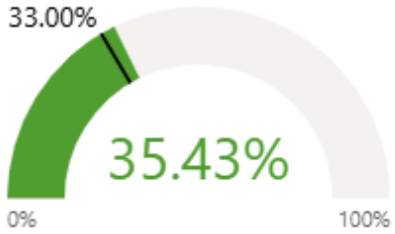
Online Inquiry	8	
Common App	5	6
International Agent	6	6
Transfer Portal	6	10
Direct Apply	5	10
High School Visit	5	12
Referral	4	11
College Fair	4	

Enrolled
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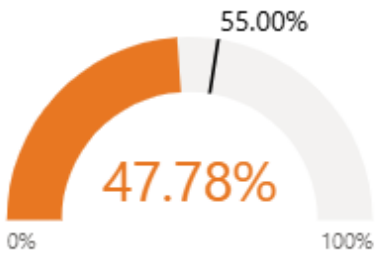
Prior Cycle **55** ▼ -17 (-30.9%)

Online Inquiry	8	
Transfer Portal	6	
Common App	4	5
International Agent	5	5
Direct Apply	4	
High School Visit	4	10
Referral	4	8
College Fair	3	

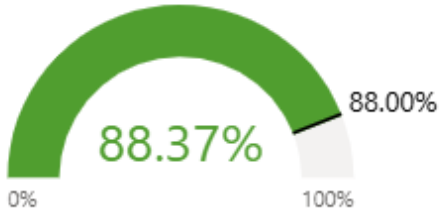
Admit % vs Admit % Benchmark



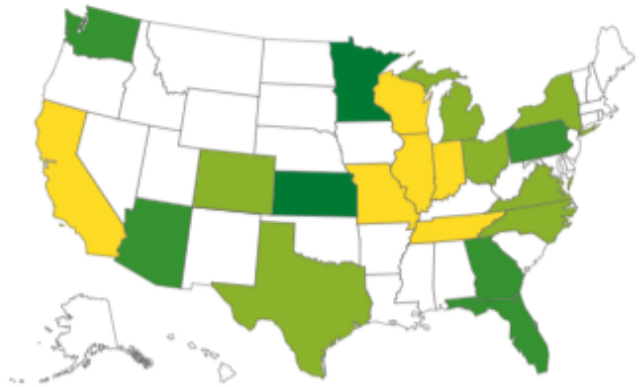
Yield % vs Yield % Benchmark



A&R % vs A&R % Benchmark



Net Deposits # by State (Domestic)



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Pipeline

2024 | 2025 | 2026

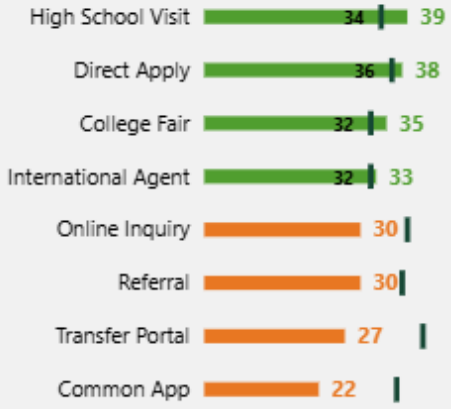
FTC | TRE

Fall | Spring

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Apps
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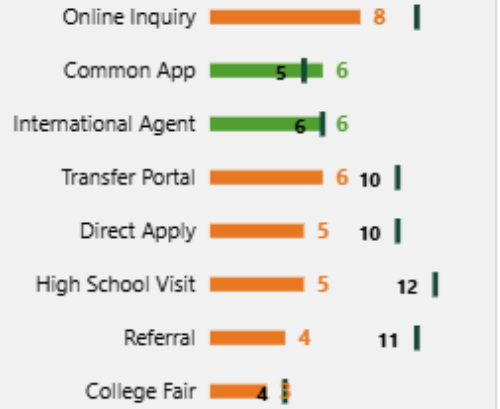
Admits
90

Prior Cycle 81 ▲ 9 (11.1%)



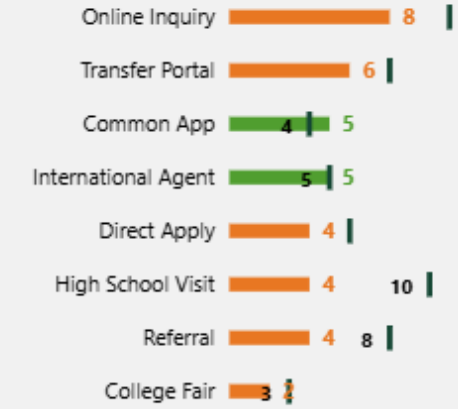
Net Deposits
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Prior Cycle 69 ▼ -26 (-37.7%)

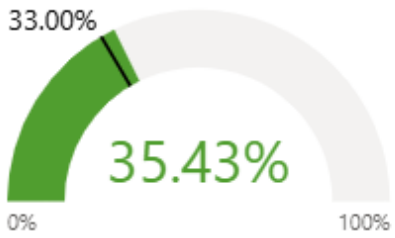


Enrolled
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Prior Cycle 55 ▼ -17 (-30.9%)

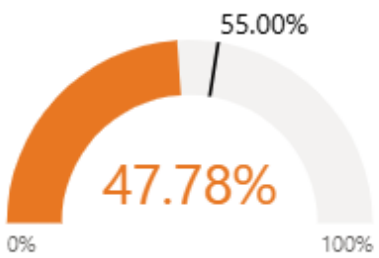


Admit % vs Admit % Benchmark



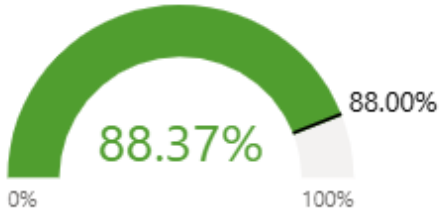
Admit Rate % is the percentage of applicants who are offered admission.

Yield % vs Yield % Benchmark



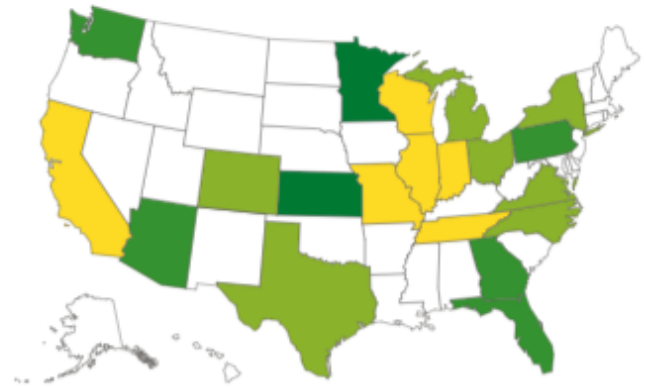
Yield % is the % of admitted students who actually paid a deposit (committed to attend).

A&R % vs A&R % Benchmark



A&R % (Acceptance & Registration Rate) is the % of deposited students who actually show up and enroll.

Net Deposits # by State (Domestic)



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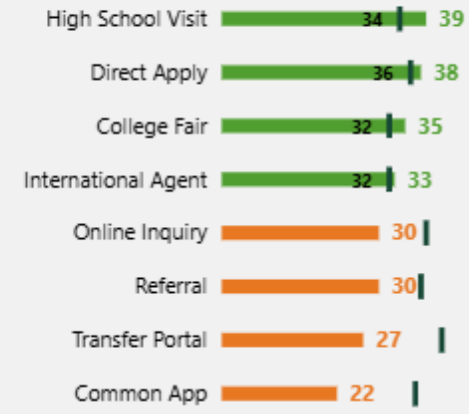
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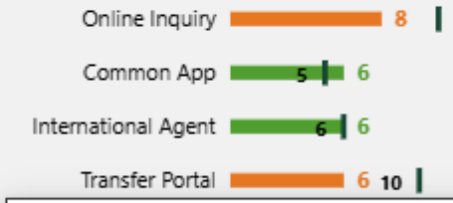
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Minnesota

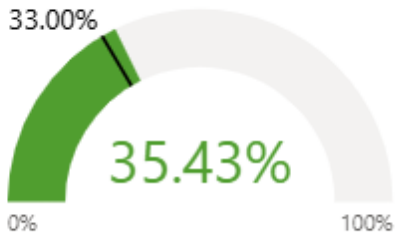
Net Deposits #

4

Prior Cycle **1**

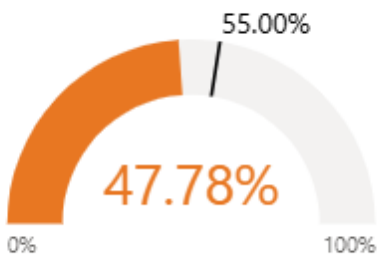
Variance ▲ **3 (300.0%)**

Admit % vs Admit % Benchmark



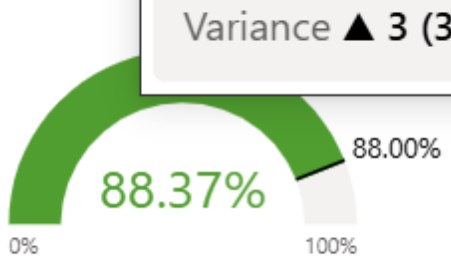
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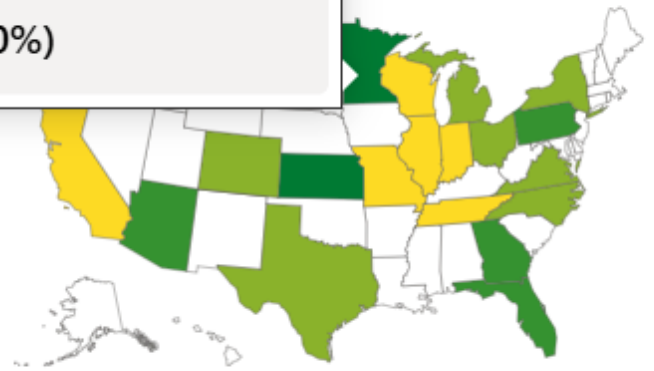
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mestic)



2. Progressive Disclosure Framework

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Deliver the right information,
at the right time.



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CONCEPT

Show only **what is needed**, **when** it is needed.



Too Much
Overwhelming



Just Right
Relevant, Timely, Essential



Actionable
Clear & Decision-Ready

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CORE LOGIC

1

START SIMPLE

High-level insights at a glance

- Key information only
- Easy to understand
- Quick to take action

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CORE LOGIC

1

START SIMPLE

High-level insights at a glance

- Key information only
- Easy to understand
- Quick to take action

User **chooses** to explore more

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2. Progressive Disclosure Framework

Deliver the right information, at the right time.

CONCEPT

Show only **what is needed**, **when** it is needed.



Too Much
Overwhelming



Just Right
Relevant, Timely, Essential



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DRILL DEEPER

Only if they need to

- More details
- Advanced insights
- Custom exploration

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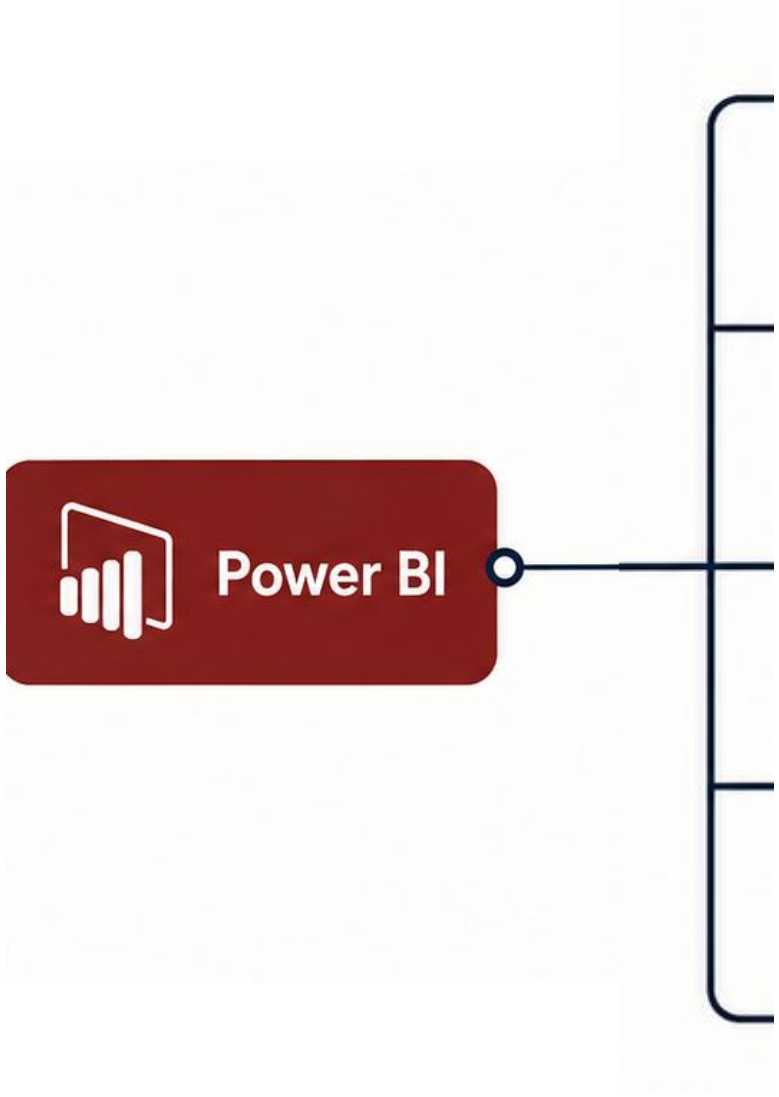
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3 STAY IN CONTROL

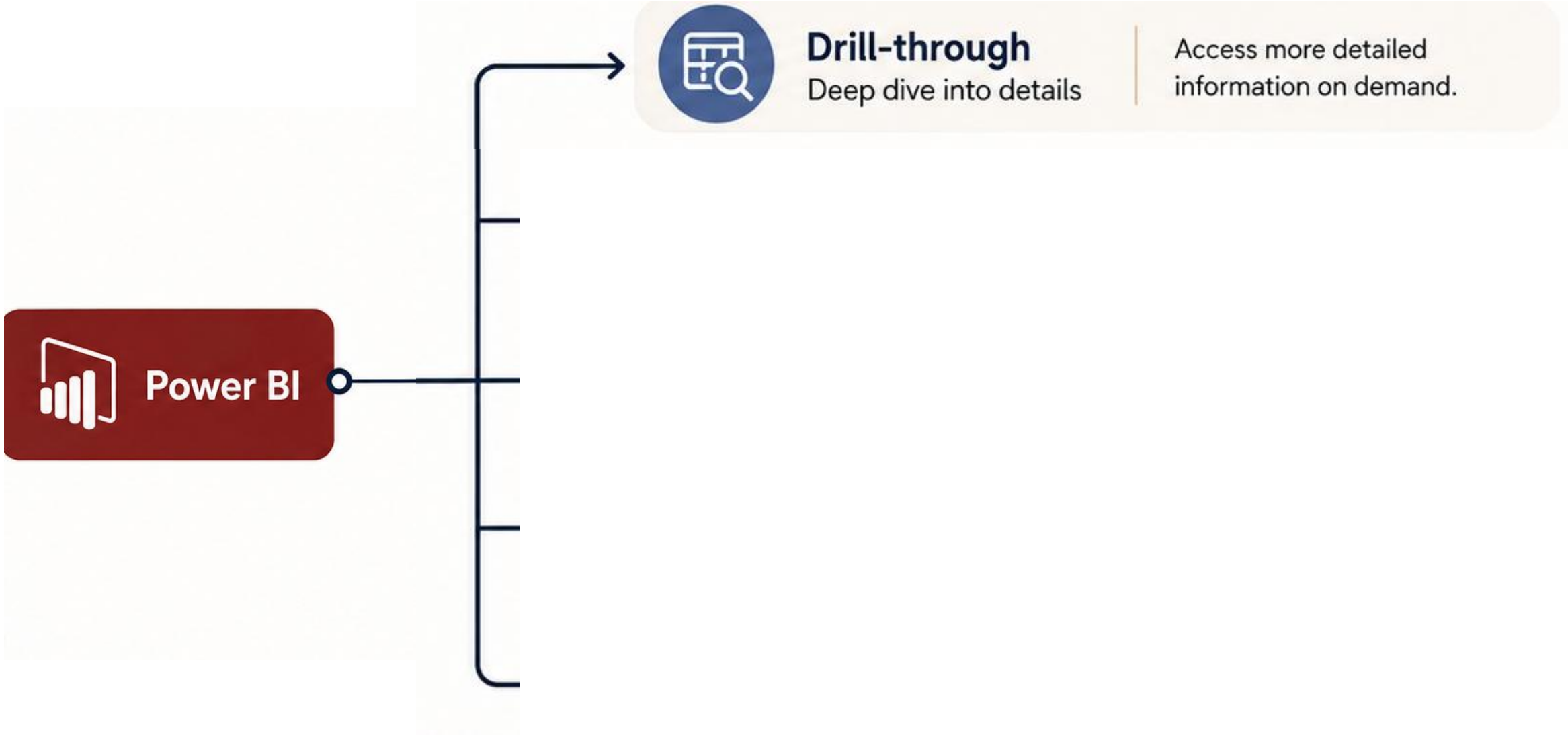
Always user-driven

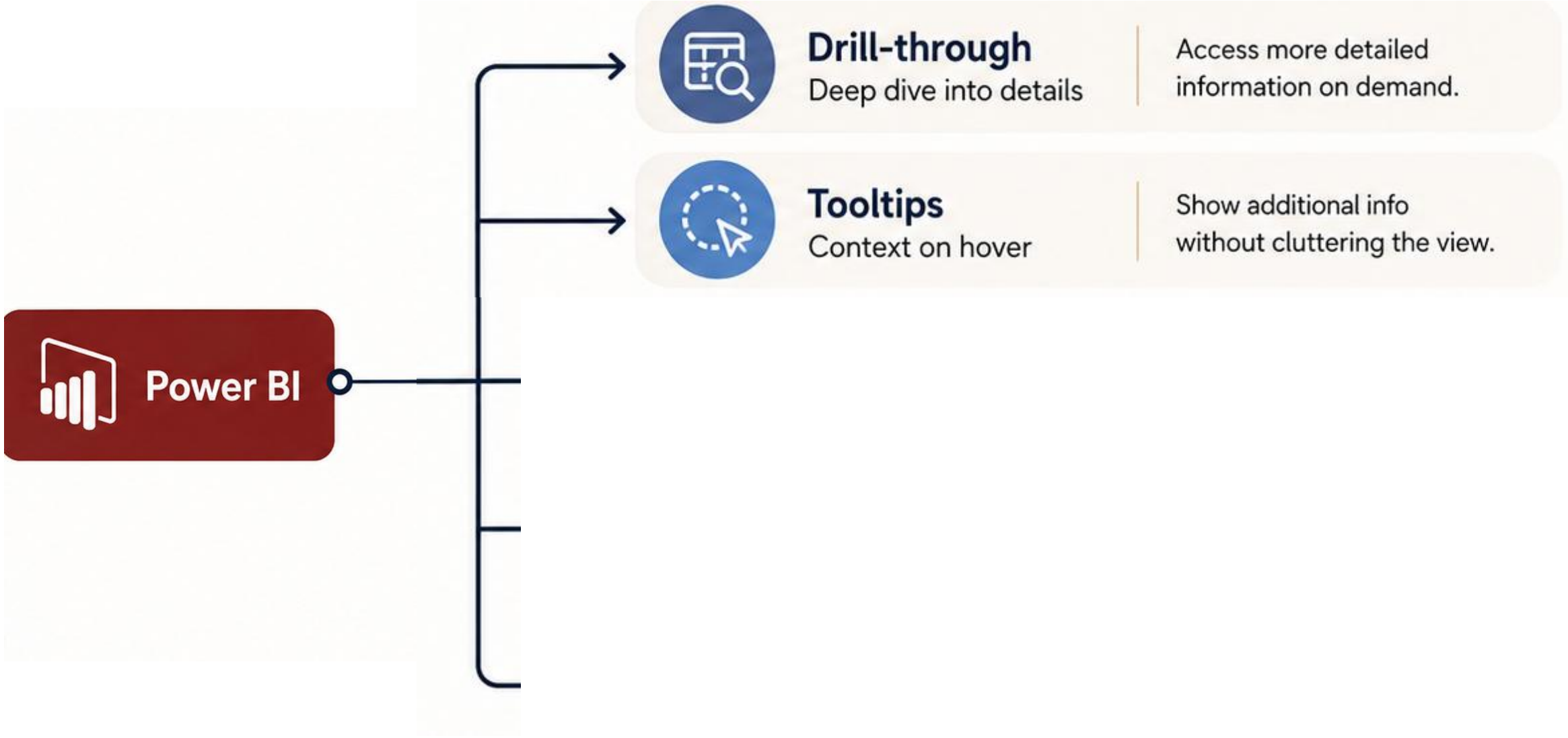
- Flexible navigation
- Relevant discovery
- No information overload

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Power BI
Drill-through
Deep dive into details
Access more detailed information on demand.


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Tooltips
Context on hover
Show additional info without cluttering the view.

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Allow users to explore data at multiple levels.
Page navigation
Guide the journey
Lead users step-by-step through your story.

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Example

💡 **Power BI Storytelling Tip:**
Insight is not about showing more. It’s about **revealing the right thing at the right time**.

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Attrition Probability

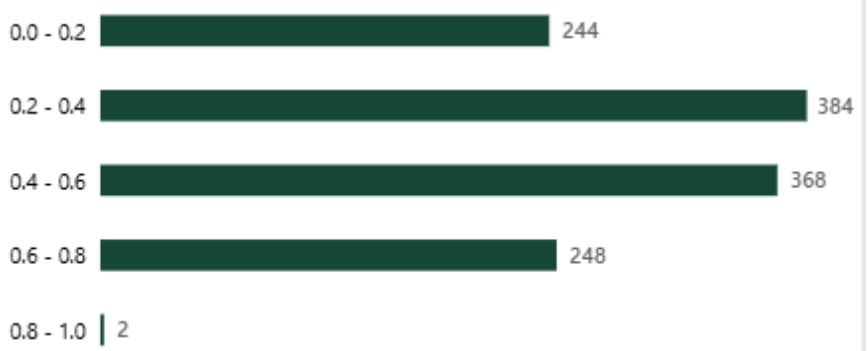
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Avg Attrition Prob Score	Students at Risk #	Withdrew This Term #
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Prior 0.41 (0.00 | 0.5% ▼)	Prior 610 (8 | 1.3% ▲)	Prior 80 (25 | 31.3% ▼)

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Avg Attrition Prob by College

Low | Medium | **High** | Critical



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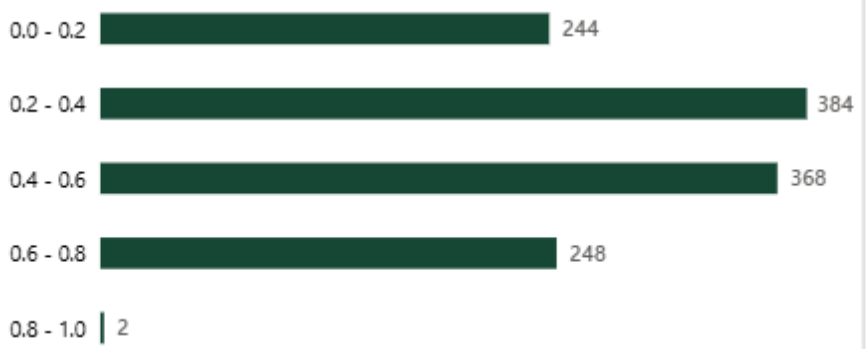
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Student Details

Risk Label

Low | Medium | High | Critical

College Name

- Arts & Science College
- Business College
- Engineering College
- Non-Degree

StudentID	Name	Risk_Label	Advisor	Email ID	Phone	Age_Group	College_Name	Residency
400021	Riley Jackson	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	rileyjackson@mst.edu	(636) 267-4456	17-19	Engineering College	Out-of-State
400025	Jamie Thompson	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	jamiet025@yahoo.com	(214) 638-7543	23-25	Engineering College	International
400073	Blake Taylor	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	blaket073@yahoo.com	(636) 409-6147	23-25	Engineering College	Out-of-State
400200	Quinn White	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	quinn.white@gmail.com	(816) 840-4457	20-22	Engineering College	Out-of-State
400357	Cameron Moore	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	cameronm357@gmail.com	(314) 647-2734	20-22	Engineering College	Out-of-State
400528	Finley Anderson	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	finleyanderson@mst.edu	(816) 452-5571	17-19	Arts & Science College	Out-of-State
400574	Harper Miller	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	harper.miller@outlook.com	(816) 934-9008	23-25	Engineering College	Out-of-State
400613	Olivia Martin	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	oliviamartin@mst.edu	(816) 540-5967	17-19	Engineering College	International
400783	Harper Miller	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	harper.miller@mst.edu	(660) 524-3162	17-19	Engineering College	Out-of-State
401000	Logan Martin	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	lmartin@mst.edu	(417) 416-1359	17-19	Engineering College	International
401156	Peyton Jackson	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	pjackson@mst.edu	(512) 569-7358	17-19	Engineering College	International
401192	Sage Johnson	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	sagejohnson@mst.edu	(636) 393-1089	17-19	Engineering College	Out-of-State
401196	Sam Smith	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	ssmith@hotmail.com	(217) 867-5155	31+	Engineering College	International
401305	Diana Perez	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	dperez@outlook.com	(660) 219-3492	23-25	Business College	Out-of-State
401358	Sam White	Critical	Long,Erica Lea	swhite@mst.edu	(512) 872-5075	17-19	Engineering College	Out-of-State
400039	Brenda Smith	High	Long,Erica Lea	bsmith@mst.edu	(573) 446-2290	20-22	Arts & Science College	Out-of-State
400240	Ethan Wilson	High	Long,Erica Lea	ewilson@outlook.com	(913) 751-8935	26-30	Engineering College	Out-of-State
400258	Drew Lee	High	Long,Erica Lea	drewl258@gmail.com	(660) 583-8056	20-22	Engineering College	International
400267	Jesse Thomas	High	Long,Erica Lea	jessethomas@gmail.com	(636) 403-7302	20-22	Engineering College	In-State
400371	Casey Lopez	High	Long,Erica Lea	casey.lopez@mst.edu	(573) 577-5703	17-19	Engineering College	In-State
400399	Olivia White	High	Long,Erica Lea	oliviawhite@yahoo.com	(913) 987-5616	23-25	Engineering College	In-State
400452	Noah Taylor	High	Long,Erica Lea	noahtaylor@mst.edu	(314) 787-3255	20-22	Engineering College	Out-of-State
400463	Logan Martin	High	Long,Erica Lea	loganm463@gmail.com	(512) 429-2988	20-22	Engineering College	In-State

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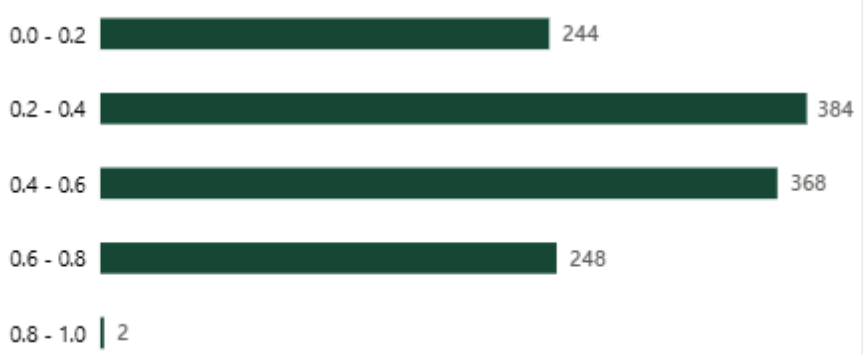
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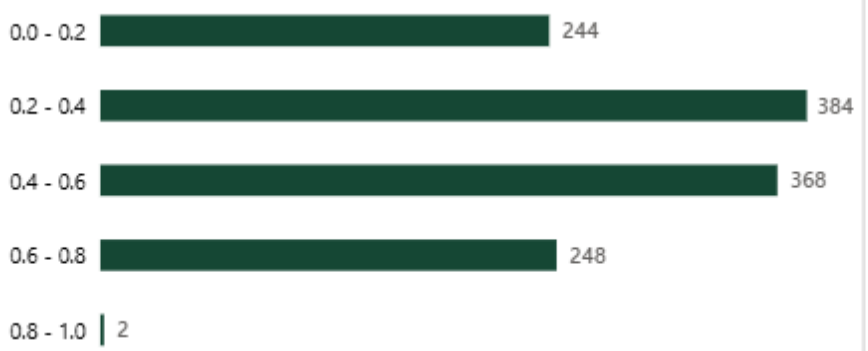
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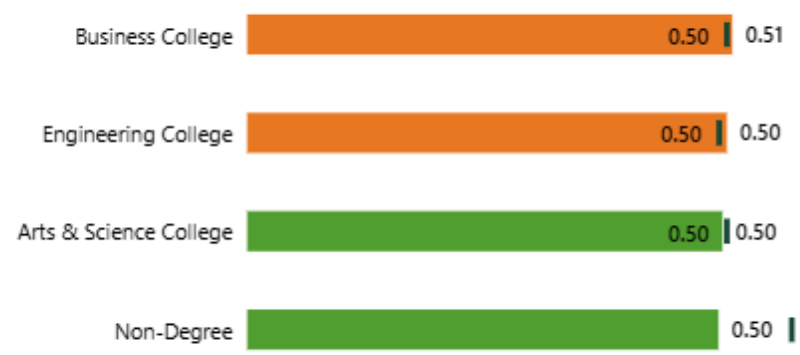
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3. The Martini Glass Framework

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CONCEPT

1. START BROAD

Introduce the big picture and set the stage.

2. FUNNEL TO INSIGHT

Narrow the focus to extract key insights.

3. OPEN UP FOR EXPLORATION

Provide space and flexibility to explore, ask questions, and discover more.

THE GOAL: Guide users from overview to understanding, then empower deeper discovery.



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THE WIDE TOP – SHARED CONTEXT

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THE OPEN BASE – EXPLORATION

Open the floor for curiosity, questions, and deeper exploration.

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Example

💡 **Power BI Storytelling Tip:**
The Martini Glass ensures that **insight is shared before exploration begins.**

UNIVERSITY OF FABRICLAND

Graduate Outcome Survey

Academic Year: 2023

Graduates	Responses #	Responses %
295	229	77.63%
PY 260	PY 185	PY 71.15%

UNIVERSITY OF FABRICLAND

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Respondents # by Outcome Category

Hover on "i" for more details | Click to explore on map

Continuing Education	Employed	Military
49	154	1

Not Seeking Employment	Still Seeking Employment	Volunteer
6	2	1

Avg. Annual Salary

$87,381.04 PY: $83,278.80 ▲

Respondents	Max	Min
104	$129,256.00	$45,196.00

Avg. Hourly Salary

$39.17 PY: $42.83 ▼

Respondents	Max	Min
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Continuing Education by Country

Right Click to Drill Down to State



Country	Continuing Education
USA	30
California	8
Texas	8
Missouri	5
New York	5
Illinois	4
Canada	9
Alberta	4
British Columbia	2
Quebec	2
Ontario	1
Total	49

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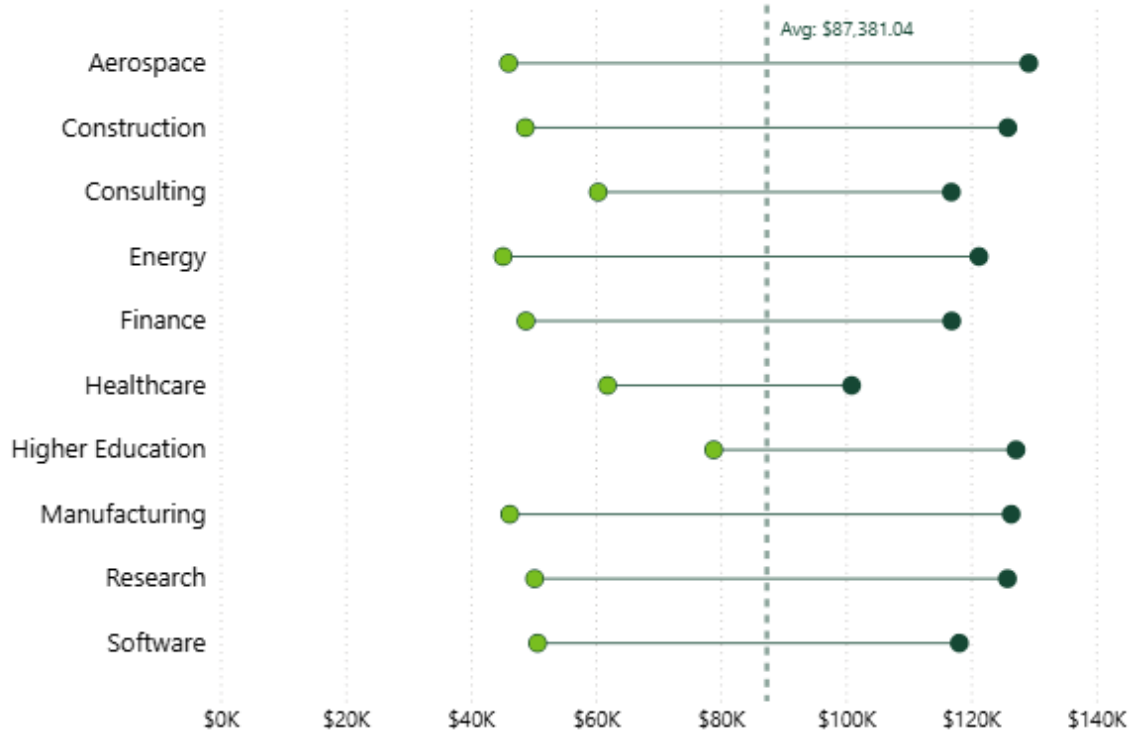
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Min Salary & Max Salary by Employer Industry (Annual)

Right click on industry type to drill down to employer name.



Which Framework to Use?

A guide to choose the right framework for the right purpose.

	1. THE COMPARISON FRAMEWORK	2. PROGRESSIVE DISCLOSURE FRAMEWORK	3. THE MARTINI GLASS FRAMEWORK
BEST FOR	Evaluating options, ideas, or items side by side	Delivering information in layers, avoiding overload	Exploring a topic from big picture to deep dive

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HOW IT WORKS	1. Compare (establish baseline) 2. Contrast (reveal differences) 3. Explain (provide reasons/implications)	1. Start simple (high-level insights) 2. Allow deeper drill only if needed	1. Wide Top (shared context) 2. Stem (guided insight) 3. Open Base (exploration)

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STRENGTHS	✓ Clear side-by-side evaluation ✓ Highlights similarities & differences ✓ Supports decision-making	✓ Reduces cognitive load ✓ Delivers just-in-time information ✓ Empowers user control	✓ Creates shared understanding ✓ Focuses conversation ✓ Encourages curiosity & discovery

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EXAMPLE USE CASES	• Product comparisons • Vendor evaluations • Feature vs. feature analysis	• Dashboard drill-downs • Reports & analytics • Onboarding & help flows	• Strategy discussions • Research & learning • Workshops & brainstorming

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HOW TO CHOOSE



Do you need to evaluate
or decide between options?

→ Use The Comparison Framework

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Do your users need information
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Do you need to build shared understanding and then dive deeper together?

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PRO TIP

You can also combine these frameworks!
Example: Start with Martini Glass to set context → Use Comparison to evaluate → Use Progressive Disclosure for deeper details.

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Don’t forget to rate our session and leave your feedback!



Wayne Jones, EdD
A.V.C. for Institutional Effectiveness & Chief Institutional Research Officer



Brianna Reddick
Associate Director of Analytics



Lakshmi Ponnurasan
Data Analyst II

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Q&A